



Enhancing Systems Engineering Academic Processes with AI at NPS: Initial Experiences

Ray Madachy, Oleg Yakimenko, Joe Sweeney,
Mark Rhoades, Douglas Van Bossuyt,
Ron Giachetti

Systems Engineering Department
Naval Postgraduate School

INCOSE International Symposium 2026
Yokohama, Japan | June 13–18, 2026



Acknowledgments

Thanks to the Air Force Research Laboratory (AFRL) and the [Scalable Asymmetric Lifecycle Engagement \(SCALE\)](#) program for supporting the graduate student team capstones and course projects assessed with AI assistance during this effort.

Introduction

- Systems Engineering graduate education depends on rigorous but labor-intensive academic processes.
- Education technician support, advising, thesis/capstone assessment, grading, and accreditation evidence require consistency and traceability.
- Staff and faculty time are constrained, while institutional and defense-relevance expectations remain high.
- The SE Department is evaluating the usage of governed AI assistants as early adopters for practical campus implementation.
- The goal is not autonomous decision making, but consistent and better human-reviewed academic products, evidence, feedback, and process continuity.

Current AI Assistant Portfolio

- **Higher Education Administrative Tool Helping Engineers Renew (HEATHER 2):** supports education technician and academic administration processes using SOPs and policy documents.
- **Capstone/Thesis Reviewer:** generates rubric-based reviews and structured assessment outputs for faculty review and student feedback.
- **Automatic Graders:** AI assisted workflows for course-level grading of assignments and formative feedback.
- These efforts are being executed locally in SE while establishing reusable patterns for broader NPS adoption.

Current AI Impediments

- Non-governmental LLMs requiring personal accounts.
- Privacy restrictions using non-governmental LLMs hamper greater capabilities. Cannot post PII student information.
- Lack of government resources to fully support these applications.
- Problem domain difficulties and LLM performance.
- Cloud computing costs.
- Local machine LLMs can alleviate some or all of the above.

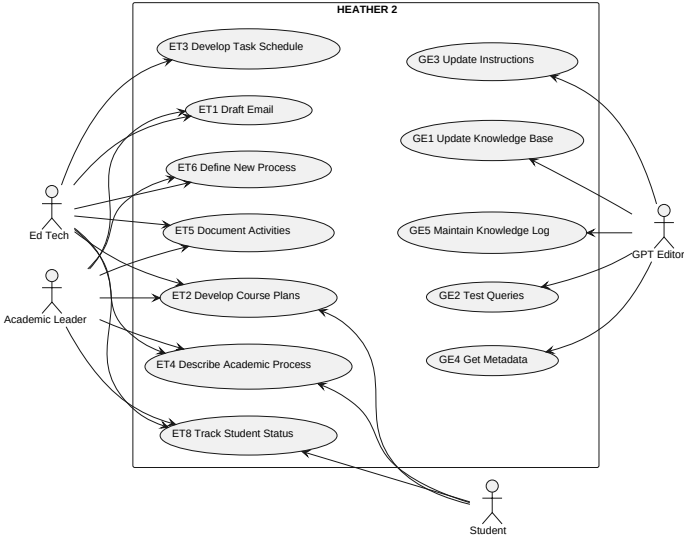
HEATHER 2: Education Technician Support

- Custom GPT grounded in SE Department Standard Operating Procedures (SOPs).
- Supports matriculation, ABET checks, enrollment management, student matrices, graduation, and routine communications.
- In routine daily usage by Ed Tech and faculty.



Illustration by HEATHER 2

Representative HEATHER 2 Use Cases



Current Documents in HEATHER 2 Knowledge Base

Document	Summary
Business Continuity Plan for SE (DL) Operations	Procedures to sustain DL academic operations during outages or disruptions.
ABET SOP for MSSE Program	Workflow for ABET/equivalency verification to determine MSSE degree eligibility.
Graduation Process SOP	Timelines, forms, and approval chains for SE DL degree and certificate completion.
New Student Enrollment Cheat Sheets	Procedures for Python matrix assignment, track designation, and academic commenting.
Matrix Management Cheat Sheets	Instructions for editing matrices, verifying certificate eligibility, and updating EDD/EGD.
Catalog Update Procedures	Step-by-step instructions for updating SmartCatalog entries for SE curricula.
Applicant Reporting Cheat Sheets	Filters, date ranges, and formatting guidelines for generating applicant data from Python.
INCOSE Certification Support SOP	Eligibility criteria and communication workflow for ASEP/CSEP via SE3100 equivalency.
Outstanding Thesis Selection SOP	End-to-end nomination, committee, and approval workflow for Outstanding Thesis awards.
Administrative and Academic Process Guides	High-level guidance on recurring responsibilities, communications, and records practices.
Education Technician Position Description (GS-1702-09)	Federal classification guidance on core Ed Tech responsibilities, authority, and evaluation.
heather.py	Current usage model for the GPT with defined use cases, associated testing data, and saved chat histories for self awareness, auditing and reporting.

Example Ed Tech Use Case Testing Results

ID	Use Case Name	Tester(s)	Date	Result	Test Session Links
ET1	Draft Email	Madachy	2025-04-22	Pass	Student Email
ET1	Draft Email	Madachy	2025-04-22	Pass	Cohort Email
ET1	Draft Email	Samaha	2025-04-29	Pass	Draft Sponsor Emails
ET2	Develop Course Plans	Group	2025-04-25	Pass	Standard Course Plan
ET2	Develop Course Plans	Bell	2025-04-26	Pass	PhD Remediation Plan
ET2.1	Develop Custom Course Plans	Group	2025-04-25	Pass	Customized Course Plan
ET3	Develop Task Schedule	Madachy	2025-04-22	Pass	Graduation Task Plan
ET3	Develop Task Schedule	Samaha	2025-05-02	Pass	Ed Tech Calendar Analysis
ET4	Describe Academic Process	Bell	2025-04-26	Pass	Candidacy Steps
ET4	Describe Academic Process	Bell	2025-04-26	Pass	PhD Exams
ET4	Describe Academic Process	Madachy	2025-04-22	Pass	Draw ABET Accreditation Sequence
ET5	Document Activities	Samaha	2025-04-29	Pass	Progress Reporting
ET6	Define New Process	Madachy	2025-04-28	Pass	Document process improvement

HEATHER 2 Example: Evaluate Proposed Student Course Changes

Here is the review and approval assessment for each of the students listed under 311-AA Ray Madachy's purview, based on the provided course planning, matrix alignment, and degree requirements for MSSE and related certs (131, 133, 282), and compliance with 2 of 7 SOPs for ABET, graduation, and scheduling.

✓ 1. [REDACTED] (311-253C) – Israeli DL Student

Status: APPROVE

Assessment:

- His future course schedule fills out all remaining MSSE requirements.
- Fully integrated into existing 311-251G and 311-262X cohort groups.
- Courses spread across quarters to ensure continuity and cohort synergy.
- 131, 133, and 282 certs all captured with courses like SE3050, SE3011, SI3400, SE3302, SE4930, SE4150/4151, SE4354, SE4003, SE3201-3203.
- No overload or term conflicts.
- Non-ABET/ABET status not specified, but nothing precludes proceeding.
- Off quarter in 27/1 is acceptable for international students.

✓ Recommend moving forward with schedule.

✓ 2. [REDACTED] (282-244C)

Status: APPROVE

Assessment:

- In 282 cert only. Certificate students are not required to follow full MSSE progression.
- Adjustment accounts for canceled offerings (SI3400 and SE3302), with reassignment to 311-262X sections.
- Completes SI3400 and SE3302 with minimal delay; standard course pacing for a certificate student.
- No overload, no conflicts. Sequencing logical.

✓ Approve schedule update with replacement SI3400/SE3302 in 27/1 and 26/4.

✓ 3. [REDACTED] (311-252C) – Israeli DL Student

Status: APPROVE WITH NOTE

Assessment:

- Enrolled in 311 MSSE and meets degree pathway via proposed plan.
- Suggestion to drop SE3050 in 26/1 and replace with SI3400 directed study with Joe Sweeney is pedagogically sound and avoids overload. SI3400 asynchronous accommodates Israeli time zone.
- 131 and 133 cert requirements are covered.
- Multiple paths built into plan (SE4354 vs SE4950), allowing flexibility based on offerings.
- Course load per quarter remains manageable.

✓ Recommend approval with Joe Sweeney's concurrence on the directed study.

...

✓ 5. [REDACTED] (721-251C)

Status: APPROVE

Assessment:

- Dual certs and MSSEM pathway.
- Cert 133 courses (SE3900, SE4930, SE4935, SE4420) previously completed.
- Later moves into 171 and SE methods track for 721 MSSEM:
 - SE4354, SE3302, SE4520, SE4353
 - SI4021, SE3011 = solid SE methods
- Has 36 units of 4-unit courses and at least 4 at 4000-level.
- Needs 1 additional 4-unit class to reach 48 units — courses from former cert 133 count (per NPS policy).
- Thesis remains pending. Once started and completed, all degree requirements will be met.

✓ Recommend approval with confirmation that thesis enrollment (SE0811) is monitored and graded on time.

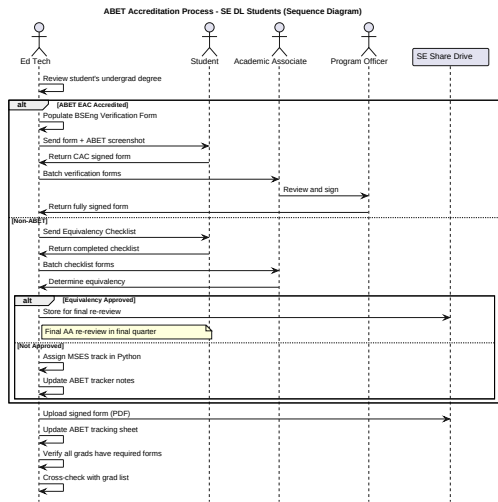
Additional Action Items for Ed Tech:

- For [REDACTED] and [REDACTED], confirm ABET/EAC or equivalency status and ensure the appropriate form is filed per [ABET SOP].
- For all 311 students, confirm updated EGD/EDD in Python and annotate matrix comments as per SOP.
- Ensure directed study for SI3400 ([REDACTED]) is set up in Python with "DL" box checked and instructor approval documented.
- Lock matrix once confirmed.

Summary:

Student	Curriculum	Status	Approval	Notes
[REDACTED]	311	Active	✓ APPROVE	Schedule fulfills full MSSE and cert requirements
[REDACTED]	282	Active	✓ APPROVE	Course substitutions are valid

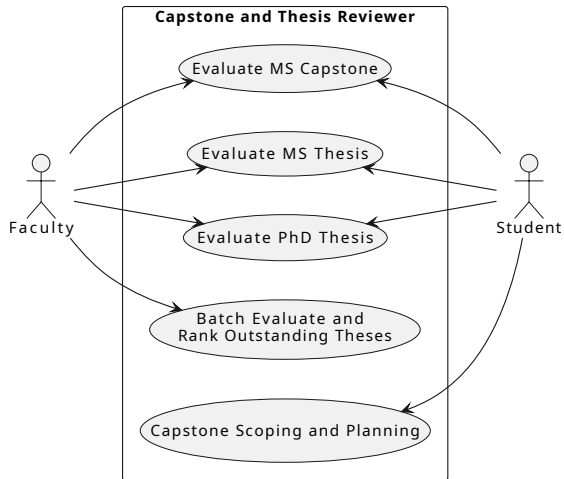
HEATHER 2 Example: Describe Academic Process



Capstone/Thesis Reviewer

- Initially faculty-facing assistant for assessment of draft or final theses and capstone reports.
- Applies SE rubrics, defense relevance, technical rigor, and writing criteria to assess NPS learning outcomes
- Produces coordinated narrative reviews and spreadsheet assessment workbooks.
- Current work is refining instructions, calibration, and experiments against faculty judgments and golden examples.
- Results support student feedback, accreditation evidence, and cohort-level analysis.
- Emergent use cases includes batch assessment for outstanding thesis ranking and student usage.

Demonstrated Capstone/Thesis Reviewer Use Cases

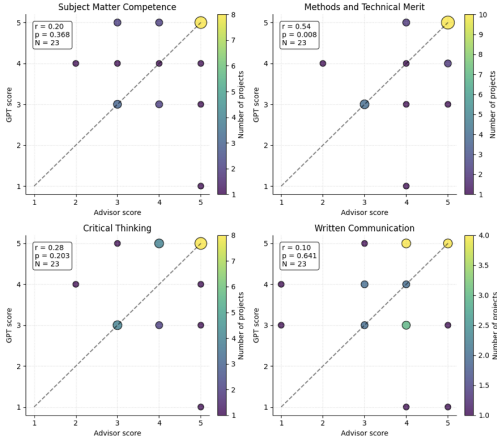


Assessment Approach

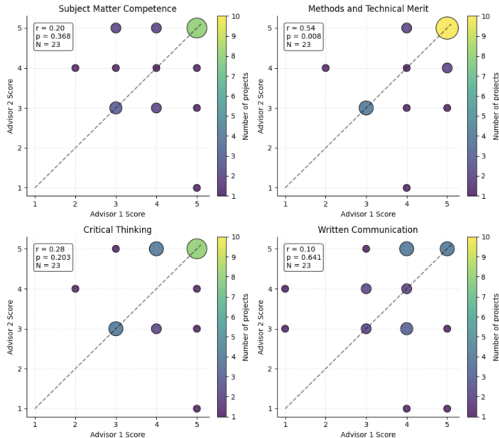
- Compare AI outputs with human baselines while recognizing variability among human reviewers.
- Use paired statistical tests, effect sizes, correlation analysis, and qualitative faculty review where appropriate.
- Clarify sample sizes and treat early statistical results as calibration evidence, not final proof.
- Calibrate against verified golden examples rather than optimizing only to historical advisor scores.
- Track review time, rework, consistency, completeness, student/faculty trust, and downstream assessment value.

Interim Assessment Calibration Analysis

Advisor vs GPT Scores by Learning Outcome
Bubble size and color = number of projects



Advisor 1 vs Advisor 2 Scores by Learning Outcome
Bubble size and color = number of reports



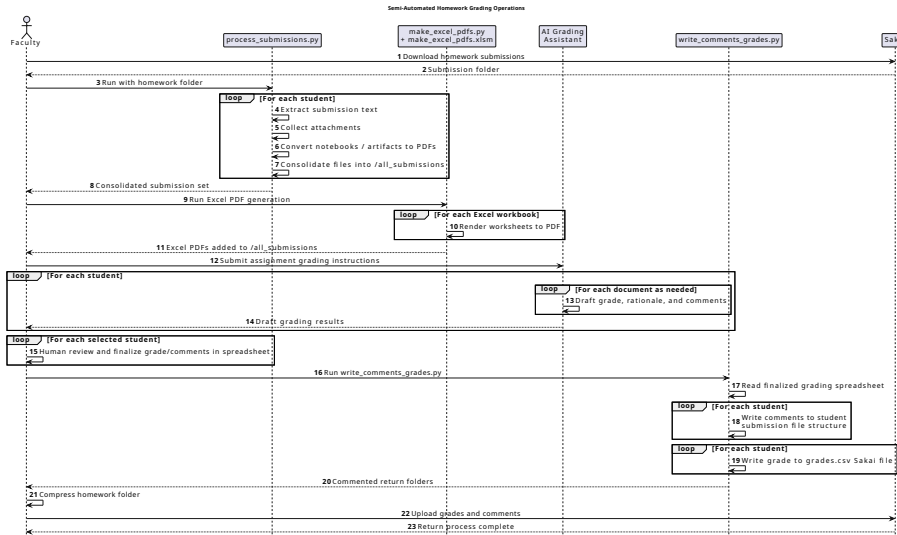
Automatic Graders

- Course-level grading assistants applied to quantitative SE homework assignments including Custom GPTs, portable chat instructions, API programs for batches, and local LLMs (in-process).
- Apply assignment-specific rubrics, identifies missing reasoning, and drafts formative feedback.
- Initial experiments compare AI-generated feedback with instructor grading and student revision outcomes.
- Outputs include a review narrative, rubric scores, common-error summaries, and machine-readable records for uploading of grades and comments.

Automated Grading Processing Constraints

- Student submissions are accepted in any format, so grading starts with artifact normalization rather than AI review.
- Most submitted artifacts are converted to PDF for reliable AI parsing and consistent visual review. Colab URLs, `.ipynb` notebooks, Excel files, and other attachments are converted into reviewable PDF artifacts.
- Text-native files such as `.txt` and `.md` can be used directly without conversion.
- Excel requires special handling for embedded graphics, charts, text boxes, formatting, and multi-tab layouts. An Excel macro run by Python is used to render each workbook faithfully.
- Sakai dictates a nested per-student folder structure with submission text, attachments, timestamps, and other files, requiring automated traversal and consolidation.

Grading Workflow Sequence



Grader Friction

- Multiple batches forced by ChatGPT limits on file uploads varying from 10-20 or sometimes 0.
- Variable performance by ChatGPT.
- Initial output for spreadsheet XML format took exceedingly long per batch.
- Fragility of the the XML spreadsheet output.
- Many regressive cycles while fine tuning instructions and fixing broken data structures.
- Combined friction forced development of API program to process an entire class at once.

- User: *This XML spreadsheet output takes way too long to print out and is fragile. Some batches take 15 minutes and sometimes your spreadsheets aren't readable. Can you suggest an alternate format that we can then convert to Excel?*
- ChatGPT: *Yes. I suggest a Python list of lists for these reasons ...*
- Outputs are now instantaneous and never break. By imploring AI to improve the collaboration, we have achieved a more harmonious process.

Example AI Grader Output

Student Name	Submission Text	#5 Effort	#5 Schedule	#5 Cost	#5 Avg Staffing	...	Total Points	Comments
ANSWER KEY	—	145.1 PM	7.8 Months	\$1,741,761	18.6 People	...	—	—
Doe, Jane	—	225 PM	9 Months	\$2,700,261	25 People	...	19.0	Jane Doe (19/22) 5. 4/5 Missed requirements... 6. 4/4 Correct annual savings... 7. 2/3 Used a size weight for cost...
Doe, John	—	163.5 PM	8.1 Months	\$1,962,429		...	18.0	John Doe (18/22) 5. 4/5 Missed requirements... 6. 4/4 Correct annual savings... 7. 3/3 Correct reuse model...
Nick, Saint	See attached spread-sheet	163.5 PM	8.1 Months	\$1,962,429	20.2 People	...	19.0	Saint Nick (19/22) 5. 4/5 Missed requirements... 6. 4/4 Correct annual savings... 7. 2/3 Used a size weight for cost...
Wilks, Jose	—	145.1 PM	7.8 Months	\$1,741,761	—	...	20.0	Jose Wilks (20/22) 5. 5/5 Correct revised COSYSMO... 6. 4/4 Correct annual savings... 7. 2/3 Used a size weight for cost...

Automated Grading Experience Summary

- Applied to 12 assignments in *Modeling and Simulation for Acquisition* (7) and *Engineering Economics and Cost Estimation* (5). Graded ~340 student assignments for ~6100 student points.
- **Zero** student complaints or comments about using AI for grading while final grades were normally distributed.
- **One** instance of a student questioning why a problem was marked wrong which was remedied by giving back a point.
- First time through for each assignment required new specific instructions and multiple grading iterations to fine tune them.
- Extensive human review of AI outputs for each assignment.
- Total time expended was more than grading manually, but savings are expected the next time.
- ChatGPT downtime forced portable instructions for other LLMs (some assignments had combined outputs with Claude).

Automated Grading Next Steps

- The grading instructions will be reorganized around reusable instruction components with transclusion, so common grading policies, output formats, and review rules do not have to be rewritten.
- API methods will be used to process entire classes at once instead of batching portions of students and assembling results.
- Scripts using APIs will enable instant turnaround for grading revisions. Local LLMs will do this at no extra cost and will set to low temperatures for reproducibility.
- The workflow will remain semi-automated. AI drafts grades and feedback, while the instructor remains responsible for final grades.

Summaries

Governance and Sustainment

- Instructions and knowledge bases are treated as controlled engineering artifacts, not informal prompts.
- HEATHER 2 updates are managed through a formal configuration management board.
- Assistant baselines include intended users, authoritative sources, prohibited behaviors, output formats, and test cases.
- Sustainment uses a DevOps continuous process: collect issues, revise sources, test behavior, approve updates, and archive baselines.
- This reduces risk as staff change, procedures evolve, and model capabilities improve over time.

Integrated Lessons

- AI academic value comes from combining institutional grounding, constrained behavior, and human review.
- SOPs, rubrics, and assessment instruments become executable knowledge sources when paired with rigorous instructions.
- Structured outputs connect individual assistance to program assessment and continuous improvement.
- Bootstrapping creates leverage. A well-governed assistant can help produce the next one.
- Trust depends on disclosure, monitoring, configuration control, and clear limits on AI authority.

Conclusions

- The current assistants are helping to form a coherent SE academic AI ecosystem.
- The common pattern is governed decision support for consequential academic processes.
- Current activities are strengthening configuration control, empirical evaluation, rubric calibration, student disclosure, and secure deployment planning.
- The integrated effort improves process continuity, assessment evidence, instructional feedback, and faculty/staff efficiency.
- Formal configuration management board will be essential for knowledge-base and instruction updates.
- The SE Department is demonstrating an early adopter path that can later be validated and adapted across campus.

References

- [1] Madachy R, Hahn H, Sweeney J, Samaha C. *Development and Testing of Custom AI Tool to Augment Systems Engineering Education Technician*. NPS Systems Engineering Dept. White Paper, May 2025.